PUBLIC BUILD-UP

Countdown milestones Planned at 1,500, 1,000, 500 and 100 days to the Games, marked by festivals of art, music, fashion and cuisine

City as a stage: Streets, public spaces and sports venues to host performances, exhibitions and mass-engagement events, designed to sustain public excitement

GLOBAL OUTREACH

Commonwealth Dialogue City to host a proposed high-profile series of ministerial meetings, business summits and cultural exchanges of member nations

Grand culmination Planned to conclude with the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting

administrative control. "In Delhi, the hosting rights were announced in 2003, but the Organising Committee (OC) came only in 2006, causing a significant delay in preparations. This time, the OC will be formed before January 2026," adds Kumar. "The 2010 Games were not owned by any authority.... Here, it is clear the buck stops with the Gujarat government, aided by the municipal corporation and OC. [Past] fiascos will not happen."

THE SPORTING REALITY

Infrastructure, however, cannot mask India's deeper sporting deficit. Cricket continues to dominate the national imagination, skewing resources and public attention away from most Olympic disciplines. The results show on the medal table. At the Paris Olympics in 2024, India returned with just six medals—one silver and five bronze. In July 2025, the Union Cabinet approved the Khelo Bharat Niti, the National Sports Policy, meant to expand grassroots participation and produce world-class athletes. But officials privately admit policy alone cannot reverse decades of neglect without sustained political will.

Governance remains a critical fault line. Most national sports federations continue to be dominated by politicians, drawn by the promise of clout and financial stakes. Poor transparency, opaque selection procedures and factional infighting persist. Doping is also a serious concern. In its last meeting with Gujarat officials, the International Olympic Committee (IOC) flagged both these lapses—an implicit reminder that institutional reform is as important as stadium construction. "Yes, the reforms are towering," admits a politician, who is a senior office-bearer in the IOA executive council. "We have inherited this rot. But despite electoral compulsions, this government does have the will."

Meanwhile, Gujarat's struggle to build a durable sporting culture persists. The Sports Authority of Gujarat (SAG), set up in 1993 as the state's nodal body, has yet to make the intended grassroots impact. Its most visible initiative is Khel Mahakumbh, the inter-school, multi-sport festival launched in 2010, feeding into the elite-focused Shaktidoot scheme. The scale is vast: the 2025 Mahakumbh drew seven million registrations. Budget allocation for sports has surged too—from Rs 2.5 crore in 2002 to Rs 521 crore in 2025–26. These funds go into organising the Khel Mahakumbh, building Centres of Excellence (CoEs) and developing district- and taluka-level sports complexes, among other facilities.

Yet ambition outstrips delivery. A Public Accounts Committee report tabled recently found SAG hamstrung by weak grassroots infrastructure, too few full-time coaches, inadequate nutrition support, slow execution and chronic underutilisation of grants, urging sharper policy direction, expert guidance and stronger funding mechanisms.

A VISION ON THE LINE

Gujarat officials argue that the Games will force overdue correction. World-class venues, they reason, will boost local sporting culture between major events. "Through a collaboration with the UK's Loughborough University, a CoE in Sports Science is planned in Ahmedabad to train coaches and other professionals," says Kumar. "We are also exploring a grant-in-aid model for [private] operators to run and maintain sports facilities while ensuring affordability for locals."

Amdavad 2030 is not just a sporting spectacle—it is a wager on urban and economic transformation. Mega-events leave behind housing, transport and hospitality assets; their true success hinges on whether the local economy can sustain and utilise them. Gujarat is betting that the talent drawn to its emerging spacetech and semiconductor hubs in Sanand, and the fintech ecosystem at GIFT City in Gandhinagar, will help do exactly that. To maximise the use of its stadiums, the city plans to host more sporting and cultural events. Ultimately, though, the Games will be judged not by glossy, packed venues but by India's ability to align politics, governance and sport into a coherent national vision. ■



"THE 2030 GAMES WILL NOT ONLY CELEBRATE **A HUNDRED YEARS OF THE COMMONWEALTH MOVEMENT** BUT ALSO LAY THE FOUNDATION FOR THE NEXT CENTURY"

P.T. USHA, *President, Indian Olympic Association*